



SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Suhail Chandhok: Appreciate the sport, not just individual heroes

In the panel 'Young Turks – A New Sporting Vision for New India' (from left to right) Hannah Muthoot (Director, Muthoot Sport, Muthoot Pappachan Group), Akhilesh Reddy (Chairman & Managing Director, Racing Promotions Pvt. Ltd.), Suhail Chandhok (CEO, U Mumba & Co-Founder, Elev8 India Sportz), and moderator Suresh Balakrishna (Chief Revenue Officer, *The Hindu Group*) explored the need to push boundaries while reimagining what it takes to build a sporting ecosystem.

From volleyball in Kerala and motorsport nationwide to kabaddi on the national stage, Hannah, Akhilesh, and Suhail reflected on the challenges and opportunities of turning vision into impact at the PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit.

"I entered sports after much of

the initial groundwork was done by my father. People have genuinely wanted to guide and support me in developing it," Hannah said.

Yet, sustainability remains a challenge.

"Can we truly build a brand? Our academies in Kerala are recognised, but to strengthen the ecosystem, we need younger players to come in through colleges and our academies. Combining all three — grassroots, colleges, and academies — is a challenge," she added.

Akhilesh entered motorsport, driven equally by passion, while acknowledging its expense.

"Motorsport has the power to create industrial establishments, generate jobs, and become a platform for research and development and technology. It can push engineers and mechanics into innovation.

"There are already kids

passionate about working on car engines. Motorsport gives them a pathway to turn that into careers, therefore boosting employment, and contributing to the GDP."

Suhail sees sport as community-building rather than just competition. "We had a team from Uttarakhand that didn't do very well (in the Yuva Kabaddi series), but we spotted one really bright young talent there.

"His team got knocked out early, so we moved him to the Puducherry team. That team made the finals, and the boy did really well. The year before he played Yuva, he was maybe earning ₹20-50,000 a year from kabaddi. Then he came through our series, made the final, got spotted by scouts in Pro Kabaddi, and earned himself a ₹78-lakh contract in the auction."

Hannah added that deeper community engagement is critical.